

Getting Ready for Your Fifth Guided AI Session

A short guide to read before you begin

This guide explains what will happen in your fifth session with the AI assistant. Reading it first means you'll know what to expect, why the session is shaped the way it is, and how to get the most out of it. It takes just a few minutes to read.

Welcome back — from turning thoughts over to setting down a heavy one

In your earlier sessions you learned to watch the mind move moment to moment — a situation sparking an automatic thought, which stirs a feeling, which shapes what you do — and you met the cognitive distortions. You stepped back and mapped the bigger picture: the problems you'd most like to be free from, and the goals you'd like to move toward. And you learned to take a single troubling thought and turn it over slowly and fairly, weighing it from several sides.

This session takes on one particular kind of thought — the kind many people carry quietly for years: the sense that something painful was your fault. Using a simple tool called the Participation Grid, you'll look at everyone and everything that was connected to a difficult event, and come to see the whole picture rather than only your own part in it. People are often surprised by what they find.

Good to know: There are no right or wrong answers here, and nothing you say is being graded. The grid simply helps you see a painful event in full — all the people, forces, and circumstances that were part of it — rather than through the narrow lens of blame.

What this session is

You'll work through the Participation Grid with the AI guide. Together you'll take one real event that has left you feeling guilty — or ashamed, or full of regret — and, step by step, look at every person, institution, illness, and circumstance that was connected to it. You'll give each one a share of the participation, and the shares add up to 100%. You always rate yourself last.

The blank grid is printed in the Annex at the end of this guide, so you can see the whole shape before you start.

Why yourself last? Because the shares add up to 100%, each person or circumstance you recognise leaves a little less for you. Many people are quietly surprised to find that, once everything is on the grid, their own part is far smaller than it always felt.

Who you'll be talking to

As before, you'll be chatting with an AI assistant set up to guide this one exercise — a friendly companion for this particular step. A few things to keep in mind:

- It is **not a replacement** for your therapist or doctor. It's guiding one exercise, not managing your overall care.
- It won't tell you what to conclude, or what your percentages "should" be. Every number on the grid is yours.
- It stays gently focused on this exercise. If you raise something else, it will kindly keep to the task and suggest saving that for your therapist.

The numbers are always yours. The guide will never suggest a percentage for you, or nudge a figure up or down. It may remind you of a number you gave earlier if you ask — but every figure on the grid comes from you.

How the session will flow

The session moves through a clear, unhurried sequence. You don't need to memorise it — the guide leads the way — but here's the shape, so nothing feels out of the blue.

Part 1 — Where you're starting from

You'll name the event, and the guide will ask two starting questions. First, about guilt: how much, from 0 to 100%, you believe you were guilty of what happened. Then, about shame: it will ask, gently and separately, how big that feeling is right now — if shame is part of this for you. These two are noted down and tracked separately, all the way through.

Two questions, on purpose. Guilt and shame are close cousins, but not the same thing — so the guide asks about them a little differently. Guilt is asked as something you *believe* ("how much do you believe you were guilty..."); shame is asked as the *size* of a feeling ("how big is it right now..."). Don't worry about getting the wording right; just answer honestly. And if shame isn't part of this for you, that's perfectly fine — you'll simply say so.

Part 2 — Swapping one word

Before anything else, the guide will set the word "guilty" gently to one side and put "participated in" or "contributed to" in its place. This isn't to excuse anything, or to make light of what happened. It's simply so you can look at the full web of causes — even the small, indirect, or involuntary ones — without the word "blame" getting in the way.

Part 3 — Building the picture

Together you'll list everyone and everything connected to the event — people, of course, but also institutions, illnesses or other biological factors, and circumstances that no one controlled. The guide

builds the whole list first, without diving into detail yet, so nothing feels rushed. Then you'll give each one a share of the participation, out of 100%, leaving yourself for last. Whatever remains after everyone else is what falls to you.

Part 4 — Looking closer, round by round

This is the heart of the session. Before rating again, the guide will walk back through each person or factor with you, asking questions that open up angles you may not have weighed — what someone knew at the time, what duty of care they had, how old you were, what no one could reasonably have foreseen. This isn't a hunt for new numbers; it's a way of seeing the event more fully, almost re-telling the story with all of its parts in view.

Then you'll rate the grid again, in a fresh column. You might keep a figure the same, or change it. Most people go round two or three times — occasionally more — until their own share settles.

The aim isn't to reach 0%. This isn't about proving you had nothing to do with what happened — that rarely rings true, and it isn't the point. The aim is a fair share, often somewhere around 15–30%. An honest figure you can stand behind brings far more relief than a zero ever could.

Part 5 — Coming back to guilt and shame

Once your share has settled, the guide returns to those first two questions — in the same words as before. How much do you believe you were guilty now? And, if shame was there, how big is that feeling now? You'll see your starting figures set beside your closing ones. Participation and guilt are related but not the same, so any change is yours to judge — not a sum to be worked out.

If shame is still there. Sometimes guilt eases but a quieter feeling of shame lingers. If that happens, the guide may ask one or two gentle questions about what the shame seems to say about you as a person. It won't try to resolve that here — it's valuable material to carry to your next session with your therapist.

Closing — your values

To finish, the guide won't talk about "responsibility" — that word can sound like guilt wearing a different coat. Instead it will ask about your values: what matters most to you, what gives your life meaning, and how you'd like to live that going forward. It's a way of turning gently from what happened toward what you care about now.

A record to keep. At the end, the guide will offer you a simple summary table — every person and factor, how the shares shifted across the rounds, your guilt and shame figures at the start and at the end, and the values you named. It's yours to keep and return to whenever you wish. Every figure in it is one you gave; nothing is added or changed.

A completed grid, as an example

Seeing a finished one can make the path clearer. Here is a grid filled in for a neutral, everyday example — a shared work project that missed an important deadline, which one person felt was entirely their fault. Notice how their own share falls as the others come into view, and how the guilt figure above the grid changes alongside it. Yours will be about your own situation, in your own words.

I believe I am 90 % guilty for missing the deadline.

Participation Assessment	1st Evaluation	2nd Evaluation	3rd Evaluation	4th Evaluation	5th Evaluation
Myself	70	40	25		
My teammates	10	20	25		
The manager (timeline)	5	15	20		
The outside vendor	10	15	20		
The software failure	5	10	10		
Total Percentage	100	100	100	100	100

I believe I am 20 % guilty for missing the deadline.

A completed Participation Grid, shown here with a neutral example. The person's own share moved from 70% to 25% over three rounds, and their belief that they were guilty eased from 90% to 20%. The aim is a fair share — often around 15–30% — not zero.

What the conversation will feel like

- **Lots of questions.** The guide leads mostly by asking, not lecturing. This is on purpose — the insights land better when they're yours.
- **One step at a time.** You'll build the list, then rate, then look closer, then rate again — so nothing piles up.
- **Unhurried.** There's no clock, and no need to have polished answers ready. The "looking closer" part especially takes as long as it takes.
- **Okay to be unsure.** If a percentage feels like it's between two numbers, just say so — the guide will help you weigh it.
- **Conversational.** It's meant to feel like talking with a knowledgeable friend, not filling in a form.

What to have ready before you start

1. **The blank Participation Grid.** It's printed in the Annex at the end of this guide — have it open or nearby. The guide will check you have it before you begin.
2. **One real but manageable event.** Something that has genuinely weighed on you — real, but, as before, not the very heaviest thing you carry. A moderate example works best for learning the method, and you can always come back to harder ones with your therapist.

3. **A quiet moment.** Set aside a stretch of uninterrupted time where you can focus and reply thoughtfully.
4. **An open, curious frame of mind.** You're here to look honestly at one event — to see it in full, not to judge yourself.

A few tips to get the most from it

- Answer honestly — the grid only reflects what you put into it.
- Take your time in the “looking closer” part. That’s usually where the shift happens.
- Let the numbers be yours; there’s no target to hit and no “right” total. A fair share matters more than a low one.
- Afterwards, keep your finished grid and, if you can, share it with your therapist at your next appointment.

What this session is not

So there are no surprises, here’s what the AI won’t do:

- It won’t diagnose you or manage your treatment.
- It won’t provide crisis support or emergency care.
- It won’t tell you what to conclude, what to feel, or how much to blame yourself — those are always yours.
- It won’t push you toward other techniques; it stays within this one exercise.

If you’re in distress. This session is a learning exercise, not an emergency service. Guilt and grief can sit close together, and looking closely at a painful event can stir strong feelings. If at any point you feel overwhelmed, or you have thoughts of harming yourself, please pause and reach out to your study clinician or your local emergency services right away. Your safety matters more than finishing the exercise.

You don’t need to prepare anything else — the AI will guide you step by step. When you’re ready, begin whenever you like.

Annex

Your Participation Grid

Keep this nearby during your session. This is the same grid your guide will walk you through. The line above the grid and the line below it hold your guilt figure at the start and at the end; the rows in between are where each person, factor, and circumstance takes its share — with yourself always rated last, in every column.

I believe I am _____ % guilty for _____

Participation Assessment	1st Evaluation	2nd Evaluation	3rd Evaluation	4th Evaluation	5th Evaluation
Myself					
Total Percentage	100	100	100	100	100

I believe I am _____ % guilty for _____

Your own participation should be evaluated after all the others, in every column.
(If shame is part of this for you, the guide tracks the size of that feeling separately, alongside the grid — it doesn't go in a row.)